

I did get one interview for a backoffice job at Manufacturers Hanover. I had a terrible interview. I talked about how I wanted to be a trader, with absolutely no thought given to the fact that the fellow interviewing me wanted somebody to work in the backoffice. Needless to say, I didn't get the job. But I learned from that interview process. I realized that the sensible thing to do was to get some experience. At the time—this was 1986—there was a shortage of backoffice people. I got a job as a temporary filing clerk and then moved to different temporary jobs, each time embroidering my CV. Anytime I was offered a position and asked if I could do it, I said that I could. I figured that I could learn how to do it once I was at the job. I did that for several months, and then I got two permanent job offers: one was from Merrill Lynch to run part of the backoffice, which paid £30,000, and the other was from Warburg Securities to be a blue button.

What is a blue button?

On the stock exchange floor, you had badges with your firm written on it and a number. The color of your badge indicated your role. Blue buttons were boys who were trainees, but who in reality were treated as slaves. The blue button job paid £7,000. So it was £30,000 on the left hand versus £7,000 on the right hand, but the £7,000 job got you on the trading floor. I thought that was clearly the place I needed to be. I still remember my interview for the job. The guy asked me about what relevant experience I had. I certainly knew nothing. I didn't read the *Financial Times*, and I didn't pretend to read the *Financial Times*. The only clever answer I gave was when he asked me whether I ever gambled.

I asked, "Do you mean like gambling on the horses?"

He answered, "Yes, exactly."

I replied, "I would never bet on anything where the odds were against me. Why would you do that?"

I didn't know whether that was the right answer or the wrong answer, but it was my instinctive answer. I got the job.

I started on South African gold shares, and literally my job was to get tea, coffee, and sandwiches, book trades, and answer the phone. I really had a miserable time on the first desk I was on. I couldn't understand what was